

How can morale and social optimism be protected when experimenting with community mobilization initiatives?

In an outcomes-focused world, the concept of piloting and experimenting with different types of social interventions is widely accepted. You try out an intervention in a particular setting. If it works, then you then roll it out more widely. If it doesn't work then abandon it. This is how things are done in an area such as medicine, and is a sound approach. However, when attempting to apply it to initiatives that involve community mobilization, describing some initiatives as 'failures' and terminating them can have unintended negative consequences, particularly if the community being worked has high levels of deprivation, is disempowered and has low social morale.

The problem is that the primary mechanism in many such community initiatives is mobilizing community members to work together to address a social problem. Community mobilization and building community morale require a sense that it is worthwhile for community members to become involved in community-building work. Community members need to believe that taking action in this way can actually result in improved outcomes for their community. To announce that an initiative has 'failed' and will be terminated runs counter to such a narrative of progressively increasing community empowerment and mobilization. This is particularly damaging if the purchaser/funder or supplier/provider then stops providing resources that the community could use to identify a more effective way to address the issue.

This problem can be avoided by purchasers/funders or suppliers/providers establishing a longer-term relationship with the community. In that case, they can truthfully position the whole process as one of trying out various possibilities. In such instances, all initiatives that the community has put its time and commitment into are therefore defined as 'successes'. They are 'successes' in the sense that something has been learnt from them and this will be used in the ongoing process of ultimately finding a solution to the community's issues. However, given the realities of funding cycles, it is usually difficult for a purchaser/funder or supplier/provider to make such a long-term, open-ended commitment.